

Stress + Chaos Test Strategy

Stress + Chaos Test Strategy

Revision: 1 Last modified: 2026-06-26T12:00:00Z

Master technical specification — Volume 8 (Testing & QA), nano-detail document **stress-chaos**, one of the seven §11.4.169 cross-cutting test-type deep-dives. It deepens 10-testing-acceptance-and-qa.md §5.9 (STRESS + CHAOS) into an implementation-ready bank mapped onto the §11.4.85 **closed-set** helper contracts (`ab_stress_run`, `ab_chaos_kill_pid_during`, ...) with chaos-injection cleanup in trap EXIT (§11.4.14) and target/hardware safety (§11.4.133). SPEC-ONLY: it describes harness, fixtures, evidence, gate, and the paired §1.1 mutation; it does not build the product. Sources cited inline by id — [OVERVIEW] = doc 10; [TM] = [../v05-security/threat-model.md]; [reconcile] = [../v03-control-plane/reconciliation-flow.md]; [ladder] = [../v02-data-plane/transport-selection-ladder.md]; [01-DP] = doc 01. Claims not grounded in the evidence base are marked **UNVERIFIED** per constitution §11.4.6 — never fabricated.

Table of contents

- 0. Scope on HelixVPN surfaces
 - 1. The §11.4.85 closed-set, instantiated for HelixVPN
 - 2. Harness — the §11.4.85 helper contracts
 - 3. Target/hardware safety (§11.4.133) + cleanup (§11.4.14)
 - 4. Fixtures — real (§11.4.27)
 - 5. Captured evidence (§11.4.69 / .85)
 - 6. Determinism (§11.4.50)
 - 7. Acceptance gate
 - 8. The paired §1.1 mutation
 - 9. Test skeletons
 - Sources verified
-

0. Scope on HelixVPN surfaces

§11.4.85 makes resilience a per-fix obligation: happy-path coverage alone is a §11.4 bluff at the resilience layer. For a VPN the resilience failures are the *dangerous* ones — a tunnel that drops mid-transfer must **not leak plaintext during the gap**; a reconcile that races a Redis drop must **not lose a delta**; a torn network-map snapshot must **never** be applied half-written. This bank exercises every HelixVPN fix under sustained load, concurrent contention, boundary inputs, and failure injection, and asserts categorised recovery with captured evidence.

Surface	STRESS dimension	CHAOS injection	Recovery invariant
coordinator reconcile	≥100 policy edits / ≥30 s churn	Redis drop mid-reconcile	no lost delta; degrades gracefully ([reconcile §0.2])
edge forwarding	sustained iperf3 transfer	SIGKILL the edge mid-transfer	tunnel re-establishes; zero leak in the gap (S9)
client transport ladder	repeated re-pick under flap	interface flap mid-flow	re-establishes < 3 s; kill-switch sealed during churn ([ladder §3])
coordinator fan-out	≥10 concurrent enrollments	partial-write of map snapshot	recovery restores a consistent (not torn) map
connector liveness	N connectors attach/detach	connector process kill	peer drops from every map within convergence budget
IPAM allocator	boundary ranges (empty/max/off-by-one)	mid-write SIGKILL of the alloc tx	no double-allocation; tx rolls back atomically

1. The §11.4.85 closed-set, instantiated for HelixVPN

§11.4.85 fixes a closed, mechanically-auditable set. Each member is instantiated below; the generic `ab_*` helper is in column 3.

STRESS (closed-set):

§ member	HelixVPN instantiation	Helper
sustained load (N≥100 OR ≥30 s, p50/p95/p99 recorded)	≥100 policy apply edits driving reconcile; ≥30 s iperf3 through the edge	ab_stress_run
concurrent contention (N≥10 parallel, no deadlock/leak)	≥10 concurrent enrollments; ≥10 concurrent WatchNetworkMap opens	ab_stress_concurrent
boundary conditions (empty/ max/off-by-one)	empty ACL; max-peer NetworkMap; off-by-one overlay / 48 range end	ab_stress_boundary

CHAOS (closed-set, applied per fix-class appropriateness):

§ member	HelixVPN instantiation	Helper
process- death injection	SIGKILL the edge / coordinator / connector mid-call	ab_chaos_kill_pid_during
network- fault injection	drop/delay/reorder via tc netem; Redis Streams partition	ab_chaos_drop_network_during
input- corruption injection	corrupt the map- snapshot file / .env mid-test	ab_chaos_corrupt_file_during
resource- exhaustion injection	edge OOM pressure; coordinator FD exhaustion; disk- full on the DB volume	ab_chaos_oom_pressure_during / ab_chaos_disk_full_during
state- corruption injection	partial-write of the network-map snapshot; mid- flight Redis lock loss	ab_chaos_corrupt_file_during (+ recovery assert)

2. Harness — the §11.4.85 helper contracts

The bank is built **only** on the §11.4.85 `stress_chaos.sh` helper library; each helper composes with `ab_pass_with_evidence` / `ab_skip_with_reason` (§11.4.69) and a mandatory trap `'...' EXIT` cleanup (§11.4.14). The helpers are run via `make chaos` (overview §9), backgrounded (§11.4.89) so the main work stream is never blocked, and dispatched by `helix_qa` under the real-time sync channel (§11.4.116).

```
# stress_chaos.sh contract surface (§11.4.85) – the only API this
# bank calls
ab_stress_run          <name> <N|secs> <fn>                # sustained;
# records latency.json p50/p95/p99
ab_stress_concurrent <name> <N> <fn>                        # N parallel;
# asserts no deadlock/leak
ab_chaos_kill_pid_during <pid> <workload> --on-kill <hook> --
# assert <cond> --evidence <dir>
ab_chaos_drop_network_during <iface|stream> <workload> --assert
# <cond> --evidence <dir>
ab_chaos_corrupt_file_during <path> <workload> --assert <cond> --
# evidence <dir>
ab_chaos_oom_pressure_during <pid> <workload> --assert <cond> --
# evidence <dir>
ab_chaos_disk_full_during <mount> <workload> --assert <cond> --
# evidence <dir>

# CHAOS: kill the edge mid-transfer, assert recovery AND no leak
# during the gap (overview §5.9)
ab_chaos_kill_pid_during "$(edge_pid)" 'ip netns exec client
# iperf3 -t 20 -c 10.10.0.20' \
# --on-kill 'sleep 3' \
# --assert 'tunnel_reestablished_within 3s &&
# killswitch_sealed_during_gap' \
# --evidence "qa-results/chaos/edge_kill_$(date +%s)/"
# the assertion re-reads the gap pcap: ZERO plaintext egress while
# the edge was dead (composes S4/S9)
```

Single-resource-owner partitioning (§11.4.119): exactly one process owns the edge data port during a chaos run; concurrent observers are read-only probes. Each chaos run owns its rig exclusively so evidence is never cross-contaminated.

3. Target/hardware safety (§11.4.133) + cleanup (§11.4.14)

Chaos injection on a VPN must be **safe for the target system and its host** — §11.4.133 forbids any unsafe write. HelixVPN's injections are all reversible, bounded, software-only:

- **No unsafe hardware/system writes.** Injections touch *process* and *namespace* state only — kill, tc netem, a corrupt copy of a *test* snapshot file, cgroup memory pressure on the *test* edge container, a tmpfs-bounded disk-full on a *scratch* mount. No kernel/voltage/clock register, no real partition, no host firewall outside the netns table (§11.4.133 (2)).
- **Bounded blast radius (§12 host-safety).** OOM pressure is applied via the test container's cgroup MemoryMax, never the host's; disk-full uses a small tmpfs scratch volume, never the host root; the edge runs rootless (§11.4.161) so a chaos-induced crash cannot escalate.
- **Cleanup is non-negotiable (§11.4.14).** Every helper installs trap '<cleanup>' EXIT: corrupt-restore (restore the snapshot from a pre-op copy, §9.2), disk-fill-cleanup (remove the tmpfs filler), process-restart (the supervisor brings the killed process back), tc qdisc del (remove netem), netns teardown. A cleanup failure is itself a §11.4.14 violation — the orchestrator runs a post-test quiescence check and FAILs the just-completed run if it left orphan state.

```
# every chaos helper's mandatory cleanup shape (§11.4.14 +  
    §11.4.133)  
trap 'restore_snapshot_from_backup; rm -f "$TMPFS_FILLER"; tc  
    qdisc del dev "$IFACE" root 2>/dev/null;  
    supervisor_restart "$KILLED"; rig/netns_down.sh' EXIT
```

4. Fixtures — real (§11.4.27)

Stress/chaos is below the unit layer: **no mocks**. The system under chaos is the real, fully-wired stack booted via containers (§11.4.76).

Fixture	What	Why real
real_edge + real_coordinator + real PG/Redis	the wired stack via containers/pkg/ boot	chaos must hit real recovery paths, not stubbed ones
policy_churn.yaml (≥100 edits)	a real sequence of policy apply commands	sustained reconcile load must be real compile+stream work

Fixture	What	Why real
map_snapshot.bin + map_snapshot.bin.bak	a real network- map snapshot + a pre-op backup	the corruption target + the §9.2 restore source
connectors_10.toml	10 real connector configs	concurrent attach/ detach must be real enrollments

5. Captured evidence (§11.4.69 / .85)

Every PASS cites the §11.4.85-mandated artifact set under `qa-results/{stress,chaos}/<run-id>/:`

Artifact	From	Asserts
latency.json	ab_stress_run	per-iteration p50/ p95/p99 within budget under sustained load
categorised_errors.txt	every helper	per-error-class counts (refused- cleanly vs crashed) — §11.4.85
recovery_trace.log	ab_chaos_*	the recovery timeline (kill→detect→re- establish)
state_delta_snapshot.json	state-corruption runs	the post-recovery state == a consistent state (not torn)
gap_pcap.pcap	edge-kill / iface-flap runs	zero plaintext / :53 during the recovery gap (S9)
concurrency_result.json	ab_stress_concurrent	N parallel ops, zero deadlock, zero resource leak

Anti-bluff (overview §0): a chaos PASS that only proves "the process was killed" is a B-class bluff — it **MUST** prove *categorised recovery* (the `recovery_trace.log` + the no-leak `gap_pcap`), or it FAILs.

6. Determinism (§11.4.50)

Chaos is timing-sensitive, so determinism is asserted on the **recovery verdict**, not the raw timing. `ab_run_n_times "chaos-edge-kill" 3` `run_edge_kill` runs $N=3$ against the same artifact MD5; the evidence-hash is over the verdict tuple (`reestablished_within_budget: bool`, `leak_during_gap: bool`, `lost_delta: bool`); all three runs **MUST** yield the identical tuple. A run where the tunnel re-establishes in 2 of 3 is **auto-FAIL** (§11.4.50, no flake escape). The raw kill→recover timings are recorded for trend (§11.4.24). Cycle-validation runs $N=10$ for the leak-critical chaos cases.

7. Acceptance gate

Gate	Bar	Evidence	Phase
SC-EDGE-KILL	tunnel re-establishes $\leq$ budget; zero leak in the gap	<code>recovery_trace.log</code> + <code>gap_pcap.pcap</code>	MVP (release-blocking)
SC-REDIS-DROP	reconcile degrades gracefully; no lost delta after recovery	<code>state_delta_snapshot.json</code>	MVP
SC-IFACE-FLAP	client re-picks transport ≤ 3 s; kill-switch sealed during churn	<code>gap_pcap.pcap</code> + ladder telemetry	MVP
SC-SNAPSHOT-TORN	partial-write recovery yields a consistent map, never torn	<code>state_delta_snapshot.json</code>	MVP
	≥ 100 edits / ≥ 30 s: p99 reconcile	<code>latency.json</code>	MVP

Gate	Bar	Evidence	Phase
SC-RECONCILE-CHURN	within SLO; no leak/crash		
SC-ENROLL-CONCURRENT	≥ 10 concurrent enrollments: zero deadlock, zero double-alloc	concurrency_result.json	MVP
SC-OOM / SC-DISK-FULL	edge refuses cleanly OR degrades; never crashes	categorised_errors.txt	MVP

Every closed defect registers a **permanent CHAOS guard** (§11.4.135): the chaos test that reproduced the failure becomes a standing regression guard in make chaos. The leak-critical SC cases (SC-EDGE-KILL, SC-IFACE-FLAP) are §11.4.132 risk-ordered first.

8. The paired §1.1 mutation

MUTATION (paired §1.1, gate CM-CHAOS-NO-LEAK-DURING-GAP):

Remove the kill-switch re-enforcement that runs BEFORE the FSM transition on tunnel drop (S9) – i.e. let the firewall briefly open

during the edge-kill recovery gap.

EXPECTED: gap_pcap.pcap now shows plaintext (and/or :53) egress during

the gap → SC-EDGE-KILL FAILs → mutation caught.

RESTORE: re-instate the pre-transition re-enforcement; re-run → GREEN.

A second mutation (CM-CHAOS-RECOVERY-RESTORES-CONSISTENT) strips the snapshot-write atomicity so a corrupt/torn map is applied after a partial-write injection; expected: state_delta_snapshot.json shows a torn map → SC-SNAPSHOT-TORN FAILs → caught. A third (CM-CHAOS-CLEANUP-PRESENT) removes a helper's trap EXIT and asserts the orphan-state quiescence check FAILs (§11.4.14). All mutations restored and the tree verified quiescent (§11.4.84) before commit.

9. Test skeletons

```
# scripts/stress_chaos.sh – SC-REDIS-DROP: Redis drop mid-
    reconcile, no lost delta (§11.4.85)
set -euo pipefail
out="qa-results/chaos/redis_drop_$(date +%s)"; mkdir -p "$out"
trap 'restore_redis; rig/netns_down.sh'
    EXIT # §11.4.14
apply_policy_edits 120
    & # ≥100
        edits churning reconcile
PID_REDIS=$(redis_pid)
ab_chaos_drop_network_during "$PID_REDIS"
    'wait_for_reconcile_quiescent' \
    --assert 'all_deltas_delivered_after_recovery && no_torn_map' \
    --evidence "$out"
# the assertion diffs the post-recovery served maps against the
    authoritative CompiledPolicy:
# every affected device's final map MUST equal the compiled target
    (no lost delta).

# SC-RECONCILE-CHURN: ≥100 edits / ≥30 s sustained, p99 within SLO
    (§11.4.85 sustained-load)
ab_stress_run "reconcile-churn" 30
    'apply_one_policy_edit_and_wait_reconciled' \
    && ab_pass_with_evidence "reconcile p99 within SLO under 30s
        churn" "qa-results/stress/reconcile-churn/latency.json" \
    || ab_fail "reconcile degraded under sustained churn"

# SC-ENROLL-CONCURRENT: ≥10 parallel enrollments, no deadlock / no
    double-allocation (§11.4.85 concurrent)
ab_stress_concurrent "enroll-10" 10 'enroll_one_device' \
    --assert 'distinct_overlay_ips == 10 && deadlocks == 0' \
    --evidence "qa-results/stress/enroll-10/concurrency_result.json"

# SC-OOM: edge under memory pressure – refuses cleanly, never
    crashes (target-safe, §11.4.133)
ab_chaos_oom_pressure_during "$(edge_pid)" 'ip netns exec client
    iperf3 -t 10 -c 10.10.0.20' \
    --assert 'edge_refused_cleanly_or_degraded &&
        helix_edge_up_recovered' \
    --evidence "qa-results/chaos/edge_oom_$(date +%s)/"
# pressure applied via the test container cgroup MemoryMax – NEVER
    the host (§12 host-safety)
```

Honest boundary (§11.4.6). This bank proves *categorised, bounded* recovery for the modelled fault set; it does **not** prove recovery under faults outside the closed set (e.g. simultaneous multi-fault, byzantine clock skew) — those are stated coverage gaps, re-armed by §11.4.118 discovery passes. The concrete recovery budgets (3 s flap, edge restart budget) are MVP **measured** targets, **UNVERIFIED** until the rig produces the `recovery_trace.log`. The "no lost delta under Redis drop" claim rests on the

Redis Streams consumer-group at-least-once semantics ([reconcile §0.3 events:* consumer group]) and is **UNVERIFIED** for the specific drop-timing until the chaos run executes.

Sources verified

- [OVERVIEW] [../10-testing-acceptance-and-qa.md] — §0 (bluff classes), §5.9 (STRESS+CHAOS strategy + helper list + edge-kill skeleton), §6 (coverage ledger), §8 (determinism/risk-order), §9 (make chaos, backgrounded), §11.4.135 regression guard. (Read 2026-06-26.)
- [TM] [../v05-security/threat-model.md] — T-CLI-T-1/T-DP-D-1 (kill-switch leak window), S9 state machine, §10 R-RACE. (Read 2026-06-26.)
- [reconcile] [../v03-control-plane/reconciliation-flow.md] — §0.2 signature flow, §0.3 events:policy/routes/devices Redis Streams consumer group coordinator. (Read 2026-06-26.)
- [ladder] [../v02-data-plane/transport-selection-ladder.md] — §3 ladder state machine + flap re-pick budget. (Read 2026-06-26.)
- [01-DP] final/01-data-plane.md — edge fail-static (I3), WG core. (Cited via overview.)
- Constitution: §11.4.169, §11.4.85 (stress+chaos closed-set + helper contracts), §11.4.14 (cleanup/quiescence), §11.4.133 (target/hardware safety), §11.4.69 (sink-side evidence), §11.4.50 (determinism), §11.4.119 (single-resource-owner), §11.4.135 (regression guard), §11.4.89 (background execution), §11.4.116 (sync channel), §11.4.84 (quiescence), §12 (host safety), §9.2 (pre-op backup), §1.1 (paired mutation).